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Vegetable waste, stagnant rainwater, and roaming livestock are seen in the market area of the Marundeeswarar Temple in Thiruvannamiyur. These images were taken on August 13. PHOTOS: B. VELANKANNI RAJ

VELANKANNI RAJ B.

It takes superhuman effort to ignore Marundeeswarar Temple Market, located prominently on East Coast Road in Thiruvannamiyur. Besides location, it has another factor that draws the eyes of passersby its way: squalor.

The market sports a medley of shops and the major attraction is the profusion of shops selling vegetables. There are 131 vegetable shops, tiny holes-in-the wall, and they are a big draw, residents of Thiruvannamiyur and surrounding areas trooping in with huge bags. In fact, this market is known as Thiruvannamiyur Vegetable Market. But that would be only two-third of the truth; as there are another 51 shops that are best described as an eclectic mix.

Among the 51, one would notice a fancy store and a hardware store not far away: the contrast is symbolic of the staggering variety of the commerce.

For the use of the space, the shop owners pay a rent to the temple.

An open space, one resembling a parking lot, is among the market's characteristics. Besides haphazardly parked vehicles, this space hosts things that do not have a business being there.

On condition of anonymity, a shop keeper points out that rotten vehicles from the shops are

Squalor reigns at Thiruvannamiyur market



dumped in this open space, which emits suffocating smelliness particularly during rainy season. Grey water also flows in this spot. The smelly vegetable dumps are not cleared regularly, leaving visitors and shop keepers to deal with nausea-inducing surroundings. As this open space is low-lying, the shop keeper notes, it retains rainwater, which further queers the pitch.

What is repulsive to humans is

appetising to stray cattle. They feast on the vegetable refuse and head back to their "quarters", the section of East Coast Road right outside the market. These stray cattle hold up traffic, and another shopkeeper points out that last week, the CM's convoy struggled its way through this section due to the bovine takeover of the road.

The shopkeepers also rue the lack of basic facilities such as toilets at the market.

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Snapshots of Pallikaranai Anai Eri before and after greening efforts.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Pallikaranai Anai Eri becomes an education centre



S. RAJA MOHAMED

Pallikaranai Anai Eri has become a “community-made eco-tourism centre” having a variety of native trees including high-oxygen liberating trees, star trees, fruit trees, medicinal and herbal trees, avenue trees, spreading over about a two-kilometre radius, naturally blessed

with renaissance islands harbouring birds, besides feeding the fishermen here an additional income.

At Anai Eri, 254 trees of educational, economic, aesthetic, spiritual importance were planted in last December 2025 for a distance of one kilometre along the bunds, and that has now been extended with another 150 trees of ecological impor-

tance for a distance of another half a kilometre. This effort was assisted by Rail Vikas Nigam Ltd. R. Dhanapal, Chief project Officer launched the tree planting programme under Chennai Metro Rail project recently at Anai Eri.

The local community has been helpful in monitoring the growth of the trees; there has also been help for labelling of trees for educative purpose.

Anai Eri is naturally blessed with three island-like structures which attract and harbour birds. These renaissance islands would also be planted in the future with palmyrah and koduk-kapul trees to harbour more birds.

Local fishermen, earning about ₹1000 a day here are knowledgeable about marine biodiversity.

(S.Raja Mohamed, a retired Joint Director of Horticulture and a senior member of Tamil Nadu Senior AgroTechnologists's Association, Chennai)



Racing car on display at Padur college

The Department of Automobile Engineering, Hindustan Institute of Technology & Science, Padur, hosted the “Red Bull Racing Formula 1 Static Car Experience” recently.

According to a press release, the event was held in collaboration with Red Bull Racing.

Red Bull Racing representatives showcased a static F1 car - RB14 and broke down the complex aerodynamics, design engineering, and performance fea-

tures of the championship-grade machinery.

The event offered aspiring engineers and racing fans an opportunity for direct engagement with technical experts with the car.

In addition to the F1 showcase, students from the Automobile Engineering Department displayed two home-built vehicles. Quiz and an interactive Q&A session were part of the event, adds the release.



Solar Mela in Alwarpet today

Citizen Consumer and Civic Action Group (CAG) is organising a Solar Mela on August 16 at C.P. Art Centre, Eldams Road, Alwarpet, from 10 a.m. to 6 p.m, bringing together solar vendors, banks and EB officials on a common platform for consumers. Those keen on switching to solar power can have answers to ques-

tions such as how much they can save on their electricity bill with rooftop solar, installation and government subsidy related queries, choosing a right vendor and financing options that are available. To invite CAG for a similar mela in your locality, call Subramani at 88072 14008/ Aswin at 9047933740



Bazaar Road in Mylapore.

Metro works, loyalty works too

With Metro Rail work taking over a vast chunk of Kutchery Road, footfall at Bazaar Road in Mylapore has reduced. Despite the odds, old enterprises on this retail street have reasons to stay positive

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

At the point where Kutchery Road is “amputated” by Metro Rail work, two streets peel away in opposite directions. The workaday realities of these two streets, Devadi Street and Bazaar Road, are also on contrasting trajectories ever since this work took over a section of Kutchery Road shutting it down for regular traffic. Devadi Street has become overly industrious working indefatigably shoulder-to-shoulder with Nadu Street to funnel vehicular traffic from North Mada Street into Kutchery Road towards Santhome High Road. It also entertains wheels from Appu Street. While wheels have increased on Devadi Street, the footfall has simultaneously reduced on Bazaar Road.

Shopping is a languid, leisurely experience; hive off the comfort factor and you detract a vital component from that experience. When Kutchery Road was fully available to motorists and pedestrians, shopping on Bazaar Road felt natural. Now, with diversions and circuitous detours, it feels forced. Unless there are strong reasons to transact business over a shop counter, people are going to find alternatives; and digital pathways keep those alternatives flowing freely.

But Bazaar Road is attractive on account of enterprises that have established a strong presence over decades of retail commerce. Amidst shops that have regularly changed their name boards and trade are a multiplicity of enterprises that have persisted with one trade and built immense social cap-

ital, installing an emotional hotline with its customers. Examples abound. Here is a handful of them.

As anywhere else, a strong USP principle works like a charm. For A. Bhaskar, who runs Jayakumar Mill (which is around 70 years old) as well as a chekku oil shop, along with his brother A. Kumar, his grinding machines stay heard on Bazaar Road above the subterranean rumble of tunnel-boring machines on Kutchery Road because of unique offerings.

The machines grind the familiar. To name a few, rice, gram, and wheat flour, turmeric, vermilion and ragi and health mixes for young mothers after childbirth. And one machine grinds *nalangu maavu* (herbal bath power), and that has made a huge difference. Besides, as Bhaskar points out, his customers value the fact that this mill dedicates a grinding machine to each variety of items to be ground. So, business keeps plopping into those wide funnel-shaped feed hoppers. The challenge, Bhaskar observes, is more from people's increasing preference for packaged foods than the reduced access caused by Metro Rail work. Bhaskar believes opening even one access route on the Metro Rail-impacted section of Kutchery Road could bring back some of the footfall.

A similar disruption has affected New Shiva Country Drugs and Herbs on Bazaar Road, says its owner R. Prakash. Nearly 90 years old, the store began as a herbal medicine shop under Prakash's grandfather and gradually expanded into pooja articles, dry fruits, and bamboo products. With monsoon come sniffles, and a rush of customers,

but through the year, there is a steady flow of commerce, thanks to older customers who grew up relying on country remedies and younger ones who have inherited that faith from their families. Prakash notes that New Shiva has branches at Thanithurai Market and North Mada Street, also in Mylapore.

Scattered presence helps, particularly in these times. Prakash notes that online business of country medicine is greater challenge to ford.

For seller of earthen pots Gunasundari N., the going is palpably tough. But the resilience is tougher still. The thinning of the customer base, she believes, has resulted largely from changing lifestyles, the earthen pots she sells cracking under the magnetic pull of ever-silver wares. The pots, once a familiar presence in Mylapore homes, are in an unequal battle with ever-silver and aluminium vessels that promise convenience and durability. Obviously, the challenge glowering at Gunasundari is not only a metallic shift in tastes. The road itself poses a challenge now, as it now draws fewer people stopping to browse or buy.

Her voice drops to a plaintive murmur when she says, “There are days I go home without earning anything.” But brining the curtains down on the business does not enter her mind. That resilience pretty much sums up the attitude of the old shops at Bazaar Road in Mylapore.

Ahead of Madras Day, Resilience Series tracks old markets in the city that are under the shadow of a major civic infrastructure work but are soldiering on with inimitable poise

The icing on the cake

Though 121 years old, The Crown Bakery on Bazaar Road stays young, thanks to suggestions coming in from Gen Zers in the family that runs the enterprise

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

At Bazaar Road in Mylapore, lined with a diversity of shops, “hoary-haired” enterprises show up with impressive frequency. Established in 1905, The Crown Bakery wins the demographic tug-of-war among these old enterprises hands down.

Established in 1905 by Kantasamy Mudaliar, the reins of the shop would be passed on to the current family, the descendants of Srinivasan, an admirable torch-bearer of this patiently baked legacy, for several decades.

While Srinivasan's daughter Bhavani Srinivasan manages the shop, the younger generation is parked in the wings, stepping in from time to time to bring its own energy and ideas to the oven.

Twenty-three-year-old Keerthana V, Bhavani's niece and Srinivasan's granddaughter and one who epitomises the Gen Z engagement, recalls a brainstorming session by the Gen Zers in the family that resulted in the introduction of ice cream cakes to the bakery's bill of fare.

The younger generation's suggestions were instrumental in the introduction of puffs and pastries and those ice cream cakes, bringing contemporariness to the bakery's repertoire.

On the subject of repertoire, the bakery also continues to make soup sticks, a simple and traditional product given to babies during teething. But there is no

cause for the old offerings (breads and buns, bun-butter jam and regular cakes) to feel threatened by this New-Age approach. The bun-butter jam remains a clear favourite with each serving prepared freshly in front of the customer rather than packaged and left on the shelf.

The old recipes remain unchanged, preserved on yellowed pieces of paper, written in an ink that defies erasure. “We do not try to fit in a particular box or overly modernise anything,” says Keerthana.

This balance is likely the reason it manages to keep its customer base as well as add steadily to it. She observes, “People have always liked what we produced over the years and hence they keep coming back.” The connection the bakery has maintained with its customers is most evident during the Yule tide. Ahead of Christmas, Crown bakery's rum-soaked plum cake, prepared with dried fruits and raisins soaked in rum for months, draws customers from across the city and beyond. Some even send cakes abroad to relatives. “I myself was craving cakes while I was in the United Kingdom and my family has sent it over multiple times,” Keerthana says.

If The Crown Bakery has managed to ford challenges in recent times, including reduced access to its doors due to Metro Rail work, it is the desire to see the enterprise survive time that is shared by family members across generations. Specifically, the Gen Z factor: there are eight grandchildren in the family. And this constituency takes pride in the bakery. Keerthana notes she or any other youngster in the family will be honoured to take it forward.



The Crown Bakery at Bazaar Road in Mylapore.

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Water moves in two directions across the Nemmeli coastal wetland — freshwater flowing east from inland lakes and tanks, and seawater moving inland through the Muttukadu estuary. Spread across more than 8,500 acres between Kelambakkam and Mamallapuram, the wetland is a meeting point of these two water systems, shaped by tides, rainfall and the seasons.

That landscape is now being reshaped into a freshwater reservoir. The first phase of Mamallan reservoir project covers 4,375 acres. A second phase is proposed for the remaining wetland.

The proposed reservoir will occupy a landscape marked by marshes, mudflats, shallow waters, salt pans and seasonal grasslands, spanning freshwater and brackish-water habitats. The wetland is also a seasonal stopover along the Central Asian Flyway, drawing migratory birds, while its waters support fish, prawns, crabs and other species that sustain fishing activity in the surrounding villages.

The wetland is also being documented from the ground up. Environmental groups and naturalists are recording its biodiversity through field surveys, documentaries, signature campaigns, rallies and a coffee-table book.

Nemmel's Last Tide, a documentary conceptualised by Deepak Venkatachalam of Suzhal Arivom, a grassroot level, volunteer-driven environmental education, research, and conservation group and produced by the Wetland Conservation Network, brings together voices from naturalists, scientists, maritime researchers, educators and fisher-folks to document what the wetland holds and what could be

Documentation as advocacy

Environmental groups are turning to documentary film-making and biodiversity documentation and other strategies to create awareness on how the Mamallan reservoir project would reshape the Kovalam–Nemmeli wetlands for the worse

lost.

According to Deepak, making people see the landscape is central to conservation. “We try to break that barrier by bringing in people and increasing the footfall to these places,” he says, describing the need to reconnect people with nature through direct experience and visual storytelling. “The landscape has so much life. It is a very complex, intricate ecosystem. It cannot be recreated at any cost once it is depleted.”

That life is reflected in the numbers. Suzhal Arivom's documentation records 232 species in the Nemmeli Wetland complex, with nearly 45,000 birds counted during the 2025-26 peak season. A count of 16,000 migratory ducks, spread across half-a-dozen species, was recorded.

The wetland is also an important node in the Central Asian Flyway, with 88 migratory species recorded.

The documentation extends beyond birds. In January 2026, Suzhal Arivom recorded a established colony of Burmann's Sundew (*Drosera burmannii*) at five GPS-verified locations. The tiny carnivorous plant survives in acidic, nutrient-poor, seasonally waterlogged soils making its presence an indicator of relatively

undisturbed wetland conditions.

A parallel effort has come from the Palluyir Trust, a group for Nature Education and Research, founded in 2021 by naturalists, through its coffee-table book *Kovalam-Nemmeli Coastal Wetland: A Biodiversity Montage*. Combining photographs with species information, the book records the wetland's birds, insects, benthic life, mangroves and other flora. Crucially, it was printed and sent to bureaucrats, MLAs and government authorities, accompanied by letters highlighting the wetland's ecological importance and concerns over the proposed reservoir. A digital version is also available on their official website.

The documentation also places these species within the wider wetland ecosystem, its mudflats, marshes, shallow waters and vegetation which provide feeding and breeding grounds for aquatic life and habitat for migratory birds. It also records the wetland's links to fishing livelihoods and

flood protection.

“The idea is we are trying as many strategies as possible to make people feel for that place and be moved by the life there,” Yuvan says. For him, the question is also whether a freshwater reservoir can ever be considered an “alternative” to this landscape. “A freshwater body does not belong by the beach,” he argues, pointing to the difference between inland reservoirs and tidal wetlands.

Fewer fish, less income

Fisherfolk from more than 16 villages depend on the Kovalam-Nemmeli wetlands, with nearly 7,000 families relying on its shallow waters to collect prawns, crabs, oysters and other species. Unlike mechanised fishers, they work largely by hand and foot, following Irall Thazhuvuthal, the traditional practice of catching prawns and fish by hand. The Paraval, as they locally call the coastal wetland, has 18 distinct habitats, with the Purattasi season (mid-September to mid-October) bringing the highest catch. During this period, a family can earn ₹1 lakh–₹3 lakh, an income that can sustain them through much of the year.

The proposed reservoir threa-

tens this livelihood system. About 5,000 acres of the wetland is proposed to be converted into an impounded freshwater reservoir, with Phase I covering 65% Kazhuveli marshland and 35% Uppan-gazhi salt pans. For fisherfolk who have depended on these waters for generations, the loss could mean shrinking incomes and a shift to unfamiliar and precarious work.

For Kovalam R. Narayanan, the impact of the Mamallan Reservoir Project can be measured in the distance between what fishing once earned his family and what it brings in today. A fisherman from Kovalam, Narayanan began fishing at 11 and has continued in the occupation for decades. The earnings have now dwindled considerably. Narayanan links the decline partly to what has happened to fishermen who once worked in the coastal wetlands. As access to the wetland has reduced with the progress of the reservoir project, he said, many of those fishermen have moved to the sea.

That has changed the arithmetic of fishing. “Earlier, there were around 500 fishermen fishing in the sea and another 500 depending on the wetlands. Now all 1,000 are going to the sea,” he said. More boats and more fishers are consequently chasing the same marine catch, he said, leaving each fisher with a smaller share. “The wetlands earmarked for the project are not an empty expanse waiting to be developed. They are a living ecosystem supporting an intricate network of species and livelihoods” said Narayanan.

Link to the documentary <https://tinyurl.com/NemmeliDoc> Palluyir Trust - @palluyir-trust.org

Rich bird life at Kovalam–Nemmeli wetlands





TN Governor soft launches MSS App

Recently, TN Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar, soft-launched the MSS App (MSME Schemes Search App) at Bharathiar Mandapam in Lok Bhavan, Chennai.

The application has been jointly developed by Swadeshi Shodh Sansthan (SSS) - Tamil Nadu Chap-

ter and Rajalakshmi Institute of Technology with the objective of enabling MSMEs and aspiring youth to easily discover and access Government schemes, financial assistance programmes through a single digital platform, says a press release. The application is designed to simplify access to infor-

mation relating to Central and State Government initiatives, particularly for first-generation entrepreneurs and citizens in rural and semi-urban areas. The initial release supports both English and Tamil, with additional features and services proposed in subsequent phases, the release adds.

Hospital performs rare surgery

SRM Prime Hospital performed a surgery of a 52-year-old man from Jharkhand. According to a press release, it is a "reconstructive surgery" which is considered rare and complex.

The patient had neglected a fracture-dislocation of his left shoulder for nearly six months. Over time, the untreated injury progressed to a chronic dislocation, leading to extensive soft-tissue scarring, formation of a pseudo-joint elsewhere, and compression of the brachial plexus, the network of nerves that controls movement and sensation in the shoulder, arm and hand.

And this surgery, performed by SRM Prime Hospital team, helped him to restore the movement in the left upper arm, adds the press release.

Using advanced surgical techniques and a multidisciplinary approach, the medical team successfully restored the shoulder to its anatomical position while carefully protecting and decompressing the major nerves and blood vessels nearby, adds the press release.

The patient was discharged after five days in the hospital with significant pain relief. He is currently undergoing a structured rehabilitation program under the guidance of the physiotherapy and rehabilitation



team and is making steady progress toward regaining strength, mobility and functional independence, says the press release.

The surgery was carried out by a multidisciplinary team comprising Dr. Nikhil Jawaharlal Nahar, Consultant - Shoulder & Orthopaedic Surgeon; Dr. Lokesh Suryanarayanan, Consultant - Plastic Surgery along with Dr. Subashini, Senior Consultant - Plastic Surgery; Dr. K Partheeban, Clinical Lead & Senior Consultant - Anaesthesia, adds the press release.

Theatre festival at school in Thalambur



The School- KFI, Thalambur, organised a two-day event called "The festival of Drama & Dialogue."

According to a press release, around 100 students from nine schools across Chennai participated in the event.

The School-KFI has been organising this festival for over 20 years now. The aim of the festival is to create a non-competitive platform for school students to encourage them to explore a theme and express their views and concerns through the medium of theatre and drama.

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Celebrate Madras Day with MTC



As part of Madras Day, the Metropolitan Transport Corporation is organising 'MTC Chennai Day 2026' with a host of competitions.

Drawing competition

For students of classes I to V, the themes are 'The Bus Transporting Me to School', 'My Family Members Com-

mute by MTC Buses', and 'My Colourful Chennai Bus'; classes VI to VIII: 'My Chennai, My Bus', 'An Unforgettable Journey in an MTC Bus', and 'MTC Buses and Green Chennai'; and classes IX to XII, 'My view of MTC Bus in 2040', and 'One-Day in the life of MTC Bus'.

Short film contest

Madras Reel, a short-film competition,

is on 'One Bus Story' where participants should drive home the message that buses play a vital role in serving commuters in their day-to-day lives. The daily life of buses, their memories, their feelings, and the city's unique culture experienced while traveling on a bus must be captured.

The short film should feature MTC buses and run for three minutes.

The photography competition is on 'Route Number tells a life story'. The photos should depict MTC buses and commuters, public transport featuring city pictures and moments. The participants should explain how the buses are interlinked with Chennai's lives.

Poetry competition is on 'Namma Chennai Bus'.

The submission link for contests: drawing: <https://forms.gle/Jnbpw4MWPAD6TMkA8>, photography: <https://forms.gle/8Scf4VwVQiXWdmT69>, short film: <https://forms.gle/wSct2ywX8KAB1iuB7>, poetry: <https://forms.gle/JbAnBm1o7nBrkv148>. Mail your queries to mtcchennaisocialmedia@gmail.com

The last date to send the entries is August 18, 2026. For details, visit <https://x.com/MtcChennai>

Workshop on making cookies

Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre is conducting a workshop on making cookies on August 20. According to a press release, the session will focus on making cookies from millets, indigenous rice varieties. Another workshop on

making beekeeping will be held on August 21. The sessions will be held at the centre's premises at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Opposite CIPET, Guindy. Prior registration is necessary, adds the press release. For details, call 044 - 29530048

Onam festivities from August 17



Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan celebrates Onam with a five-day festival titled "Bhavanonam" starting August 17 at its main auditorium in Mylapore. The events happening from August 17 to 21 are open to all and begin at 6.30 p.m.

From captivating Kathakali, Malayalam short plays, Kerala musical en-

semble like Thiruvathirakali, Mudiattam, Panchari Melam, Ottanthulal, the festival will immerse audiences in the unique charm of God's Own Country.

The events on August 23 will be held at the Kilpauk auditorium.

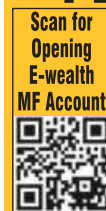
August 17 - Kathakali - Naragasura Vadham

August 18 - Kerala musical ensemble

August 20 - Malayalam short plays

August 21 - Avani - A Kerala cultural odyssey

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